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Literary Essay

Free Will and Actualization in Chiang's *Story of your Life*

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Ted Chiang's *Story of Your Life* is a work of science fiction that explores meaning in the face of a predetermined world. The story oscillates between the present work of Louise Banks and the future life of her daughter. The link between these two stories is an alien race known as the Heptapods, who are able to experience time as a simultaneous mode of consciousness. Upon learning Heptapod B (the Heptapod written language), Louise begins to experience time like they do, with fragmented chunks of her future displacing her present. Her temporal dislocation has consequences for her own free will, in addition to that of her daughter's. Moreover, Chiang seems to be expanding upon what we believe to be free will, introducing ideas of teleological free will and actualization. In Chiang's *Story of Your Life*, Louise's daughter is the focal point, representing the beauty of teleological free will and actualizing a predetermined future.

In order to understand the implications of Chiang's teleological free will, a few points must be made regarding the Heptapod understanding of time. According to Louise, "I have glimpses of when Heptapod B truly reigns, and I experience past and future all at once; my consciousness becomes a half-century-long ember burning outside time" (Chiang 140). Thus, an understanding of Heptapod B implies knowledge of one's future. According to Louise, "knowledge of the future was incompatible with free will" (137). From this, we can surmise that Louise has lost her free will and is unable make the choices other humans make with total agency.

Louise's loss of free will does not trouble her as a character. Unlike many, she views predestination with a resigned ease, not bent on fighting it, opting rather to accept it. According to her, "Within the context of simultaneous consciousness, freedom is not meaningful" (137). For beings that understand time differently than we do, freedom may be an illusion granted to

those fated to live sequentially. Rather, Louise states, “I would never act contrary to the future” (137). From this statement, we can gather that Louise is content with her newfound worldview. This newfound worldview, one of teleological free will, runs counter to one of humanity’s most basic logical systems.

Early in life we as humans are taught that cause comes before effect. One swings a bat, and as a result the ball goes flying through the air. Yet, cause and effect mean little to one who knows both the cause and subsequent effect. The causal action no longer holds the same importance as it does in a sequential timeline. As such, Louise’s understanding of free will differs from our own. Consider a beam of light acting according to Fermat’s principle (116). As a variational principle, the beam of light will either follow the minimum or maximum predetermined path. Thinking of this philosophically, the beam of light knows where it is going. As such, its purpose is teleological. It knows its destination and knows what it must do to get there. Louise’s free will can be thought of in much the same way. She is guided through life not by cause and effect, but by a greater teleological purpose only she is privy to. She even states, “[It was] an instinct that I felt right in following” (133), ensuring the validity of her teleological purpose. From this, we can gather that teleological free will endows one with the responsibility to ensure the future. Like an actor reading her lines, Louise is content to move through her life actualizing events as they unfold. Thus, it is possible to understand Louise’s new world view through the lens of performative language.

As Louise becomes accustomed to Heptapod B and teleological free will, she begins to understand the importance of performative language. Performative language is a phenomenon that occurs when one can only perform an action by speaking certain words. For example, during a wedding, everyone anticipates the words: “I now pronounce you husband and wife”. Everyone

knows they are coming, but until those words are spoken, the ceremony is unofficial, and celebration does not begin. Heptapod language functions similarly to this analogy. Heptapods know what will be said in any given conversation, but, until the events have unfolded it remains unofficial. Although they know what is coming, it in no way strips the present of its importance. They must speak the words and act their part in order to bring the event to fruition. According to Louise, “they used language to actualize” (138). Actualization is a process which validates the future known by the Heptapods as they experience “the present”. Because Louise is fluent in Heptapod B, she too must actualize her future and follow her teleological purpose. Chiang’s introduction of actualization is a radical new way of understanding our role in existence: we are stewards, ensuring the flow of time into the future is actualized. Yet, Louise’s role in actualizing the future means she must bring a daughter into the world knowing her predestined fate.

Louise is bound by teleological free will to actualize her future and give birth to her daughter. However, her experience as a mother is elevated by her foresight: “I’ll feel elated at this... unique mother-child bond” (144). Although Louise knew she would give birth, it did not lessen the beauty inherent to it. In fact, almost all of the anecdotes Louise delivers about her daughter are characterized by a tone of admiration, awe, and love. Many of the anecdotes also capture commonplace events in a child’s life: her first steps, first-time drinking, and college graduation. Through these vignettes we see what appears to be a very average childhood. Yet, Chiang’s message lies in the mundane nature of these events. Louise’s bond with her daughter was not diminished by her actualizing the future. By all standards, it seems to have given her an appreciation for the ordinary events comprising her daughter’s life. Thus, Louise’s daughter represents the beauty in following one’s teleological purpose and actualizing their future. Actualization does not result in a life of mundane recurrence, rather fulfillment and gratification

stemming from actualization. The ultimate evidence of this lies in the line: “Do you want to make a baby?” and I smile and answer, ‘Yes” (145). In choosing to have her daughter, Louise undeniably verifies the validity of the teleological world view and actualization. Understanding Louise’s daughter’s role in *Story of Your Life* makes the conclusion far more palatable, and the genre far more obvious.

When reading and analyzing *Story of Your Life*, Louise’s daughter must occupy the forefront of one’s mind. It is tempting to brush her off as a mere subplot in favor of the seemingly higher stakes science fiction. However, if this is the case, one may as well read any number of generic alien encounter science fiction stories and leave *Story of Your Life* on the shelf. At the time the story is being narrated by Louise, her daughter does not exist. In reading her anecdotes with her daughter, they are all categorized by the future tense: “Why?’ you’ll ask again. You’ll be three” (130). By speaking of the daughter only in the future tense, Chiang is creating a plot line that has yet to occur. Since it has yet to occur, every event in the story works to actualize that future. By creating a future plot line and making it the focal point of the story, Chiang reveals his intentions behind writing *Story of Your Life*.

Story of Your Life is a conte-philosophique, or a philosophical story. As such, the science fiction conventions exist only to serve the philosophical idea behind the story. Chiang’s intentions with *Story of Your Life* are to present an alternate view of free will, one that does not leave humans automatons, slaves to a predetermined future. Rather, he seeks to make us stewards of time, actualizing the future and giving us, “a sense of obligation to act precisely as we knew we would” (132). In this, there is an inherent beauty and purpose. We see our path through the universe and are bound by teleological purpose to actualize it. Yet, Louise and a select few other linguists are bound to this purpose. The rest of humanity, including Louise’s

daughter have free will. Louise even states, “You’ll do what makes you happy” (113), and “you’ll live in the present tense. In many ways it’s an enviable state” (137). In this, there is an inherent duality to humanity: those who have read the book of ages, and those who have not. Neither side is worse off than the other, but they are moved by different forces. Some, by the freedom of choice and others by the teleological need to actualize their reality. Through Louise and her daughter, we experience this duality uniquely through their mother/daughter bond. Yet, as stated previously, there is beauty in both aspects of free will. Tender, human moments such as, “the... girl who used to trundle out of my bedroom draped in a dress and hat and four scarves from my closet” (112), still hold emotional value and catharsis. Thus, by reading Chiang’s story as a concrete work of science fiction, this beautiful, philosophical duality is lost alongside the beauty of a mother’s bond with her daughter.

As the focal point of *Story of Your Life*, Louise’s daughter represents the beauty of teleological free will and actualization. For many, predestination limits human freedom and by extension, the autonomy we have as individuals. Yet, to Louise, there is beauty in following one’s teleological purpose. By following this purpose, Louise is endowed with the responsibility to actualize her future, regardless of the minimums and maximums she may experience. In doing this, she eventually gives birth to her daughter. Her daughter, the most important character, is symbolic of the beauty in following one’s teleological purpose. The tender moments they share are evidence not of mundane recurrence, but of appreciating the beauty in the present moment. The duality between mother and daughter, teleological free will and free will, and science fiction and conte-philosophique make *Story of Your Life* a story of unparalleled depth. While free will may not be as vital to humanity as we are led to believe, certainly, Chiang, Louise, and Louise’s daughter all compel us to enjoy the present moment and savor our concrete existence.

Works Cited

Chiang, Ted. *Stories of Your Life and Others*, 2015. Print.